

Linux boxed out of Xbox

Microsoft is updating the Xbox to fix a bug that allows Linux to be installed on it.

Xbox only runs software approved by Microsoft, which usually involves promising to pay taxes for each game sold. There is no version of Linux that is approved by Microsoft for use on the Xbox. However, you can overcome this by put-



ting a specially crafted file such as a saved Mech Assault game on the memory stick. The file in reality was some Linux code.

The controversy surrounds the fact that the Xbox Live Service updates the Xbox without asking for your consent. The legality of this is being questioned by experts and consumers.

Cell jam

Though using cell phone jammers—devices that produce waves to block cell phone signals—is illegal in the UK, Global Gadget sells five such devices through its Web site, www.globalgadgetuk.com. One of them resembles a mobile phone and has a blocking range of 10



to 15 metres. The expensive ones can jam cell phones within a 50-metre range. Another set of devices can turn off only the camera feature of the phones.

Iceberg Systems, UK (www.icebergsystems.co.uk), is developing Safe Haven that combines hardware transmitters with a software loaded into a camera phone handset. The imaging systems of the phones nearby get turned off when the handset is taken into a room, or a building containing the Safe Haven hardware. Though the company is currently focusing on controlling the imaging side of the handset, the technology can be adapted to block loud ring tones, or text messaging in schools.

IEEE to secure existing operating systems

The Institute of Electrical and Electronics Engineers (IEEE), has decided to outline certain basic security requirements for general-purpose (GP), commercial, off-the-shelf (COTS) operating systems.

The proposed IEEE P2200, Base Operating System Security (BOSS), will provide security functions such as cross-platform security, identification, authentication access control and key cryptographic con-



cepts. This project will run under the guidance of the US National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST), and will adhere to the International Organization for Standard's (ISO) Common Criteria framework. Apart from IEEE 2200, other related developments are the formation of Information Assurance Standards Committee, and standards such as the IEEE P1618 and IEEE P1619.

KaZaA enters P2P VoIP Telephony

KaZaA co-founders, Janus Friis and Niklas Zennstrom, have launched a P2P-based Voice over Internet Protocol (VoIP) telephony service called Skype (www.skype.com). They claim it to be the first Internet phone service to use peer-to-peer software. In an interview, Friis said that it took them 6 months to develop the software that has already scored 375,000 downloads. Free World Dialup (FWD), a

rival phone service, relies on lots of servers to maintain the calls. Thus, Friis believes that in the long run, FWD will not be able to provide top quality. The advantage that Skype has is that it connects even when the broadband users are behind NAT (Network Address Translation), which does not use VoIP based on SIP (Session Initiated Protocols). All that is needed is Skype software installed on both the computers.



Spam

Un 'Earth' ing spammers

Earthlink, the ISP, has decided to take the war on spammers to the next logical level, by suing two spammer rings—one located in Alabama, USA and the other in British Columbia, Canada—for about \$5 million. The spammers had reportedly sent about 250 million commercial e-mails for male potency products, pornography and online dating services. In addition, the Canadian ring reportedly put up Web sites with pages that appeared similar to well-known commercial Web sites, such as Amazon and PayPal.com, and retrieved confidential information from unsuspecting visitors.

Big problems

Analysts say that the DDoS (Distributed Denial of Service) attacks on three leading anti-spam sites in August 2003 were caused by spammers sending away copies of the SoBig.F worm. These worms also cause infected systems to download programs that turn the infected hosts into e-mail distribution hubs that could well rain havoc on their adversaries.

